

TAKEOUT DOUBLES

ABOUT THE DEALS

You will always be in the South position. Either you or partner may be the Takeout Doubler.

(Strictly speaking a Takeout Double is a **CALL**, not a bid, so the term is used loosely here.)

TAKEOUT DOUBLE SUMMARY

Note that the following really is just a Summary, not a full-blown lesson.

The Takeout Double is one of the oldest conventions in Bridge.
In it's simplest form it means "Partner, I have a good hand, please pick a suit."

It is necessary that you and partner agree on when a double is for takeout, and when it is not.
Here are some suggestions:

- The bid that is doubled is a suit bid, not notrump.
- Neither the Doubler nor his partner have made any call other than pass.
- The bid that has been doubled is below game level.

There are three categories of Takeout Double.

- The classic one where you have opening strength and support for all unbid suits.
- The one-suited hand which is too strong for an overcall.
- The notrump type hand which is too strong for a non-jump notrump overcall.

Here are the various guidelines:

Classic	• 13+ points* • no more than 2 cards in doubled suit • at least 3 cards in the other suits
One-suited	• 17 or more points • a quality suit 5 cards or longer
Notrump	• balanced notrump type hand • more than 18 points • good stoppers in doubled suit

* When evaluating your hand for a Classic TO Double you may count short-suit points, just as if you were responding to partner's opening bid. The idea is that partner will be choosing a suit which you can support. Don't go overboard though, because partner really hasn't bid that suit yet!

You may disagree with all these guidelines, many will. By all means stick to yours. But if your partnership doesn't have an agreement then these are a good start. They are here because the Deals that follow are based on them.

Classic Double:

The partner of the Takeout Doubler should assume that the double is of the Classic type because it usually will be. Then, if Doubler later indicates one of the other types he can adjust.

Partner's actions are as follows:

- 0-8 points or fewer - bid a suit at the cheapest level
- 9-11 points - jump in a suit
- 12+ points - cuebid the opponent's suit; forcing to game
- 8-10 points - bid notrump at cheapest level if balanced and with a stopper in opponent's suit
- 11-12 points - jump in notrump if balanced and with 1+ stoppers in opponent's suit
- 13-15 points - bid 3NT if balanced and with 2 stoppers in opponent's suit
- "some" points - pass for penalties holding 6 good cards in opponent's suit; partner is expected to lead a trump

The Doubler's next bid will be a natural bid dependent on his partner's response to the double. The 0-8 point range is the largest spread and so creates the largest problem for the Doubler, who should proceed cautiously.

One-suited Double

If Doubler ignores partner's choice of a suit and bids his own suit that indicates he has the 17+ point type of Takeout Double. It shows an Overcalling type of hand, but one which is too strong to Overcall. Responder should then bid naturally based on the knowledge of Doubler's hand which is known to contain a good 5+ card suit.

Notrump

Holding a 15-18 point balanced hand with a good stopper in the opponent's suit you would just overcall 1NT.

You show a 19+ point balanced hand by first doubling, then bidding notrump. Partner should proceed just as if you had opened 2NT.

Opener's Partner bids:

If your partner makes a Takeout Double and the next player says anything other than pass then you are no longer required to bid. This is because your partner gets another chance to bid and doesn't have to let the opponents play the doubled (or perhaps redoubled) contract. So if you **do** bid in this situation it is called a "free bid", one that you weren't forced to make. With a bad hand you would probably just pass, but if you have a distinct suit preference you should say so immediately rather than waiting until the bidding gets to a high level.

The topic really merits another 25,000 words.
Instead we have 25 examples.

Board: 1
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 1NT
Declarer: North
Lead:  7

Board: 2
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead:  J

Board: 3
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 4 
Declarer: South
Lead:  10

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 2 
Declarer: West
Lead:  J

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 4 
Declarer: North
Lead:  K

Board: 6
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead:  3

Board 1

East Deals

None Vul

♠ J 3
 ♥ 9 6 5
 ♦ K Q 2
 ♣ J 10 8 4 2

♠ A Q 8 6

♥ 7 4 2

♦ 9 8 3

♣ K 7 5

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 10 7 4 2

♥ A J 8

♦ J 7 6

♣ Q 3

♠ 9 5

♥ K Q 10 3

♦ A 10 5 4

♣ A 9 6

West

North

East

South

1 ♠

Dbl

Pass

1NT

All Pass

1NT by North

Lead: ♦ 7

The bidding has been as shown.

The minimum requirements for a Takeout Double are 12 points, no more than two of Opener's suit, and at least 3-cards in the other suits. You just squeak by so you double. Partner says 1NT and it is your bid again.

With no suit fit you can't even count a point for your doubleton so you have just 13 HCP. Partner's bid shows 8-10 so you waste no time in passing. Don't worry about the ♠s, partner says he has them covered.

Board 2

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ 9 5
♥ K Q 10 3
♦ A J 10 5
♣ A K 6

♠ 10 3

♥ 9 6

♦ 9 6 4

♣ 10 9 8 4 3 2



♠ A Q 8 6

♥ 7 4 2

♦ Q 8 3

♣ Q 7 5

♠ K J 7 4 2

♥ A J 8 5

♦ K 7 2

♣ J

The bidding has been as shown.

Partner is showing you 8-10 points and no 4-card ♥ suit.

With no Major fit you are happy to play in notrump, knowing partner can stop their suit. Partner's 8-10 points added to your 17 is a probable game so you bid 3NT.

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
			1 ♠
Dbl	Pass	1NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			
3NT by East			
Lead: ♣J			

Board 3

East Deals

None Vul

♠ 10 5
 ♥ J 8
 ♦ Q 8 3 2
 ♣ J 10 7 3 2

♠ 7 6 4 3

♥ 9 6 2

♦ 9 4

♣ A K 8 6



♠ A Q J 9 2

♥ 5 4

♦ K J 10 6

♣ Q 5

♠ K 8

♥ A K Q 10 7 3

♦ A 7 5

♣ 9 4

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
		1 ♠	Dbl
Pass	2 ♣	Pass	2 ♥
Pass	4 ♥		
All Pass			
4 ♥ by South			
Lead: ♠ 10			

The bidding has been as shown.

You have 16 HCP and two more points for the fifth and sixth ♥s. That is too strong for a simple overcall. Instead you double. Partner responds 2 ♣.

You bid 2 ♥, describing your hand as a 1-suited hand, too strong to merely overcall. Partner bids the ♥ game and you pass.

Board 4

South Deals

Both Vul

♠ 7 4
 ♥ J 5
 ♦ K 8 7 3 2
 ♣ Q 7 6 2

♠ J 10 9 6 3

♥ 6 4 2

♦ Q

♣ A J 10 5



♠ A 8 5
 ♥ K Q 7 3
 ♦ A J 10 5
 ♣ 9 4

♠ K Q 2

♥ A 10 9 8

♦ 9 6 4

♣ K 8 3

West	North	East	South
			1 ♣
Pass	1 ♠	Dbl	Pass
2 ♦			
All Pass			
2 ♦ by West			
Lead: ♠ J			

The bidding has been as shown.

You should double. This is a special case of the Takeout Double, where the opponents have already bid two suits before it gets to you. Since they apparently have at least 20 points, you should have a solid hand with at least 4-4 in the two unbid suits. A hand just like this one.

Partner bids 2 ♦. What do you say next?

Just pass. This is obviously a fight for the partscore and you have the advantage because you have found a fit. However, you suspect partner is quite weak.

Board 5

North Deals

None Vul

♠ A 10
 ♥ 8 4
 ♦ J 4 3 2
 ♣ K 6 5 4 2

♠ J 8 5 3
 ♥ 10 9 6 2
 ♦ Q 9 6
 ♣ 7 3



♠ K Q 9 6 4 2
 ♥ Q 7 5
 ♦ 8 7
 ♣ 10 8

♠ 7
 ♥ A K J 3
 ♦ A K 10 5
 ♣ A Q J 9

<i>West</i>	<i>North</i>	<i>East</i>	<i>South</i>
	Pass	2 ♠	Dbl
Pass	3 ♥	Pass	4 ♥
All Pass			
4 ♥ by North			
Lead: ♠ K			

The bidding has been as shown.

Pretty good hand you have. Certainly good enough to make a Takeout Double that forces partner to the 3-level. Partner responds 3 ♥.

Some questions don't have a correct answer. If partner has ♥ Q x x x along with the ♣ K and ♦ Q he would bid just as he did and slam would be cold. But if he has four small ♥s and nothing else he would bid just as he did and you probably cannot make ten tricks. On balance it is probably best to just bid the most likely reasonable contract, which is 4 ♥.

Board 6

North Deals

E-W Vul

♠ A 10 4 2
 ♥ 7 5 3
 ♦ 8 6
 ♣ K 10 6 5

♠ K 7

♥ Q J 4 2

♦ K 5 4 2

♣ Q 3 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ Q J 9

♥ A K 8

♦ A J 10

♣ A J 9 7

♠ 8 6 5 3

♥ 10 9 6

♦ Q 9 7 3

♣ 8 4

*West**North**East**South*

1♦

Dbl

Pass

1♠

Pass

1NT

Pass

3NT

All Pass

3NT by East

Lead: ♦3

The bidding has been as shown.

You have a perfect 2NT opening hand. Trouble is, the opponents have already opened. You get around that problem by first making a Takeout Double. Partner replies 1♠.

You could not say 1NT on your first bid because that would show 15-18 points. Doubling first, then bidding the lowest level of notrump shows 19-20 points. Of course in both cases you must have their suit adequately stopped. Partner does the math and bids 3NT.